

CORE FORMULA

Decline to decide now -> Specific return time -> Honour the commitment

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

When you cannot answer properly on the spot, say: 'I cannot give you the right answer now — I can have it for you by [specific time].' Then keep that commitment.

BEST FOR

- Situations where you need time to think before committing
- Pressure to answer before you have adequate information
- Buying time without evasion or dishonesty
- Delaying a decision that needs more input or reflection

PHRASE BANK

Deferment Phrases · Buying time with a deadline

- "I cannot answer that properly right now. I can get back to you by end of day."
- "That deserves a better answer than I can give you on the spot — give me until tomorrow morning."
- "Let me sit with that — I will come back to you by [time]."
- "I am not in a position to commit to that today. I will have an answer by Friday."
- "I do not want to answer that badly. Can I have until Thursday?"
- "That needs more thought. I will send you my view by noon."
- "I cannot say yes or no right now — I can say yes or no by Wednesday."
- "Give me 24 hours — not to avoid it, but to answer it properly."

Acknowledge Urgency · When they need it faster than you can give

- "I understand you need this quickly — my fastest honest answer is by X."
- "If you need it now, my provisional answer is Y — but I want to confirm that by Z."
- "I can give you my best current read now, with the caveat that it may change."
- "If the decision cannot wait, I would say X provisionally."

Professional Deferrals · Buying time in work settings

- "That is a fair question — I want to check the numbers before I answer it. I will confirm by tomorrow's stand-up."
- "I would rather send you an accurate answer this afternoon than a rough one now."
- "Let me take that away as an action — you will have my answer by Thursday's meeting."
- "I want to consult the team before committing them. I will close this out by Friday."
- "Good challenge. I do not want to improvise the answer — give me until end of day."
- "I will put time in my calendar for this today and reply by five."

Personal Deferrals · Time to process, without distance

- "I care about getting this right more than getting it fast — can we talk tomorrow evening?"
- "I am not avoiding you — I need a night to sit with what you said."
- "That deserves a real answer, not a tired one. Breakfast tomorrow?"
- "I want to respond from a calmer place. I will come to you in the morning."
- "This matters to me, which is exactly why I do not want to answer on the spot."

Deferring Under Pressure · Holding the pause when pushed

- "I understand the pressure to decide now. A rushed answer would cost us more than a day's wait."
- "You can have a fast answer or my real answer. My real answer arrives tomorrow at nine."

- "Pushing me to answer now will get you my most cautious no. Give me until Monday and you may get a yes."
- "I am not going to commit on the spot — this is exactly the kind of decision that deserves a night."
- "If you need it decided in this meeting, my answer is no. If it can wait until Thursday, it is a genuine maybe."
- "The deadline I can promise is noon tomorrow. I will not miss it."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Vague deferral: 'I will let you know...'
Better: I need to think about it.
Best: I cannot give you the right answer now. I will come back to you by [specific time].
2. Weak: Endless deferral with no committed return
Better: I am still thinking it through.
Best: Specific time commitment made and kept.
3. Weak: Provisional answer presented as final
Better: I think the answer is yes, but I want to check.
Best: Provisionally yes — I will confirm by X.

DECISION TREE

If You are pressed for an answer you cannot give well right now

Decline to answer now. Give a specific time you will return.

"I cannot give you the right answer on the spot. I can have it by [time] — would that work?"

If They need an answer now and cannot wait

Give a provisional answer clearly labelled as provisional.

"If you need something right now: provisionally, yes. I want to confirm that by end of day."

If You have been deferring the same decision for multiple days

Either answer or be honest that you will not change your mind.

"I have been sitting on this — I need to either decide or admit I am avoiding it."

If You defer frequently and people stop trusting the deadlines

Only defer when you will genuinely return. Then return.

SCENARIOS

Salary or scope negotiation: asked for your number on the spot

Defer with a specific return time rather than guessing. — "I need to think about that properly. Can I come back to you by end of week?"

Being asked to commit to something you have not thought through

Name that you need time. Give a specific time. — "I do not want to commit to that without thinking it through. Can I give you an answer by Thursday?"

Emotional conversation where you need time to process

Defer without making it feel like avoidance. — "I want to respond to that properly — not right now. Can we talk tomorrow morning?"

Technical question outside your current knowledge

Defer with a commitment to check. — "I want to verify that rather than guess. I will confirm by end of day."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When you know the answer already — deferring when you could decide now signals avoidance.
- When the other person needs an answer urgently and deferment will cause real harm or delay.
- When the pattern of deferring to this person is already eroding their trust in your reliability.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the bad on-the-spot answer

Notice one moment today when you gave an answer on the spot that you were not confident in.

Day 2 — Specific time commitment

In one deferral today, give a specific time rather than 'I will let you know.'

Day 3 — Keep the deadline

Set a deferral deadline and return on time.

Day 4 — Provisional vs deferred

Practise the difference between 'I do not know yet' (defer) and 'my best current view is X but I want to confirm it' (provisional).

Day 5 — Acknowledge urgency

When someone needs an answer faster than you can give it, give a provisional answer clearly labelled as provisional.

Day 6 — Own the avoidance

Notice any deferral you are making not to improve the answer but to avoid giving it. Address it.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did you keep your deferral commitments? Were your eventual answers better? Did people trust the deadlines?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I name a specific return time — not just 'later'?
- Did I keep the commitment I made?
- Was the deferral genuine — not avoidance?
- Did I offer a provisional answer when one was possible?
- Did I avoid deferring habitually on things I already know?
- Did I return with a better answer than I would have given on the spot?
- Did people seem to trust the deferral deadline?